

TOPIC 7: Commonwealth of the Philippines

List of Reading Materials:

- 1. The 1935 Constitution**
- 2. Commonwealth Act No. 34**
- 3. Commonwealth Act No. 44**
- 4. Inauguration of the Commonwealth**
- 5. Quezon's Speech**
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- 7. Commonwealth Act No. 1**
- 8. Annual Report of the United States High Commissioner to the Philippine Islands
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Introduction to the Commonwealth of the Philippines, 1935-1946

Established through the Tydings-McDuffie Law, the Commonwealth government from 1935-1946 was designed as a transitional administration in preparation for the country's complete independence. During this period, the Filipinos were given the power and responsibility to manage their domestic affairs under the American supervision. Led by Manuel Quezon as the first President, the Commonwealth tackled the economic and social problems that beset the country during the said period.

This part of the compilation includes the 1935 Constitution which laid out the legal foundations and basic principles of the government; Quezon's speeches that mention important issues during his presidency; and key Commonwealth laws that were passed in response to the pressing needs at that time such as the National Defense Act, Eight Hour Labor Law and Women's Suffrage. Through these documents, teachers and students will have a deeper understanding on the economic and socio-political situation of the Philippines during the Commonwealth period.

“The 1935 Constitution” Official Gazette of the Republic of the Philippines.

One of the important provisions of Tydings McDuffie Law was the organization of constitutional convention that would frame the fundamental laws of the country. After the Philippine Legislature accepted the Tydings McDuffie Law in 1934, delegates of the convention were also elected wherein Claro M. Recto was elected as its President.

The 1935 Constitution provided the legal foundations of the Commonwealth Government which was a ten-year transition government before the US would grant the Philippines its independence. Some of its important characteristics include: (1) a unicameral legislature through the National Assembly; (2) six-year term of the President and Vice-President without re-election; (3) bill of rights that protect the citizens and; (4) rights of suffrage by male citizens which shall be extended to women two years after the adoption of the constitution.

The 1935 Constitution was amended in 1940 which abolished the unicameral legislature and replaced by a bicameral legislative body composed of the Senate and House of Representatives.

EXCERPT:

CONSTITUTION OF THE PHILIPPINES

The Filipino people, imploring the aid of Divine Providence, in order to establish a government that shall embody their ideals, conserve and develop the patrimony of the nation, promote the general welfare, and secure to themselves and their posterity the blessings of independence under a régime of justice, liberty, and democracy, do ordain and promulgate this Constitution.

Article I.—THE NATIONAL TERRITORY

Section 1. The Philippines comprises all the territory ceded to the United States by the treaty of Paris concluded between the United States and Spain on the tenth day of December, eighteen hundred and ninety-eight, the limits of which are set forth in Article III of said treaty, together with all the islands embraced in the treaty concluded at Washington, between the United States and Spain on the seventh day of November, nineteen hundred, and in the treaty concluded between the United States and Great Britain on the second day of January, nineteen hundred and thirty, and all territory over which the present Government of the Philippine Islands exercises jurisdiction.

ARTICLE II.—DECLARATION OF PRINCIPLES

Section 1. The Philippines is a republican state. Sovereignty resides in the people and all government authority emanates from them.

Sec. 2. The defense of the State is a prime duty of government, and in the fulfillment of this duty all citizens may be required by law to render personal military or civil service.

Sec. 3. The Philippines renounces war as an instrument of national policy, and adopts the generally accepted principles of international law as a part of the law of the Nation.

SEC. 4. The natural right and duty of parents in the rearing of the youth for civic efficiency should receive the aid and support of the Government.

SEC. 5. The promotion of social justice to insure the well-being and economic security of all the people should be the concern of the State.

ARTICLE III.—BILL OF RIGHTS

SECTION 1. (1) No person shall be deprived of life, liberty, or property without due process of law, nor shall any person be denied the equal protection of the laws.

(2) Private property shall not be taken for public use without just compensation.

(3) The right of the people to be secure in their persons, houses, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures shall not be violated, and no warrants shall issue but upon probable cause, to be determined by the judge after examination under oath or affirmation of the complainant and the witnesses he may produce, and particularly describing the place to be searched, and the persons or things to be seized.

(4) The liberty of abode and of changing the same within the limits prescribed by law shall not be impaired.

(5) The privacy of communication and correspondence shall be inviolable except upon lawful order of the court or when public safety and order require otherwise.

(6) The right to form associations or societies for purposes not contrary to law shall not be abridged.

(7) No law shall be made respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof, and the free exercise and enjoyment of religious profession and worship, without discrimination or preference, shall forever be allowed. No religious test shall be required for the exercise of civil or political rights.

(8) No law shall be passed abridging the freedom of speech, or of the press, or the right of the people peaceably to assemble and petition the Government for redress of grievances

(9) No law granting a title of nobility shall be enacted, and no person holding any office of profit or trust shall, without the consent of the National Assembly, accept any present, emolument, office, or title of any kind whatever from any foreign state.

(10) No law impairing the obligation of contracts shall be passed.

- (11) No *ex post facto* law or bill of attainder shall be enacted.
- (12) No person shall be imprisoned for debt or nonpayment of a poll tax.
- (13) No involuntary servitude in any form shall exist except as a punishment for crime whereof the party shall have been duly convicted.
- (14) The privilege of the writ of *habeas corpus* shall not be suspended except in cases of invasion, insurrection, or rebellion, when the public safety requires it, in any of which events the same may be suspended wherever during such period the necessity for such suspension shall exist.
- (15) No person shall be held to answer for a criminal offense without due process of law.
- (16) All persons shall before conviction be bailable by sufficient sureties, except those charged with capital offenses when evidence of guilt is strong. Excessive bail shall not be required.
- (17) In all criminal prosecutions the accused shall be presumed to be innocent until the contrary is proved, and shall enjoy the right to be heard by himself and counsel, to be informed of the nature and cause of the accusation against him, to have a speedy and public trial, to meet the witnesses face to face and to have compulsory process to secure the attendance of witnesses in his behalf.
- (18) No person shall be compelled to be a witness against himself.
- (19) Excessive fines shall not be imposed, nor cruel and unusual punishment inflicted.
- (20) No person shall be twice put in jeopardy of punishment for the same offense. If an act is punished by a law and an ordinance, conviction or acquittal under either shall constitute a bar to another prosecution for the same act.
- (21) Free access to the courts shall not be denied to any person by reason of poverty.

ARTICLE V.—SUFFRAGE

SECTION 1. Suffrage may be exercised by male citizens of the Philippines not otherwise disqualified by law, who are twenty-one years of age or over and are able to read and write, and who shall have resided in the Philippines for one year and in the municipality wherein they propose to vote for at least six months preceding the election. The National Assembly shall extend the right of suffrage to women, if in a plebiscite which shall be held for that purpose within two years after the adoption of this Constitution, not less than three hundred thousand women possessing the necessary qualifications shall vote affirmatively on the question.

Commonwealth Act No. 34
An Act to provide for the holding of a plebiscite on the question of woman suffrage

Article 5 of the 1935 Constitution states that "The National Assembly shall extend the right of suffrage to women, if in a plebiscite which shall be held for that purpose within two years after the adoption of this Constitution, not less than three hundred thousand women possessing the necessary qualifications shall vote affirmatively on the question."

In line with this, the National Assembly passed the Commonwealth Act No. 34 on September 30, 1936. This Act provided the holding of a plebiscite for women's suffrage on the following year. Commonwealth Act No. 34 mandated women who met the same voting qualification as men to participate in the said plebiscite.

On April 30, 1937, the plebiscite was held wherein 90% or 447, 725 of women voted in favor of suffrage paving the way to women's active participation in the Philippine politics.

Excerpt:

Section 1

Pursuant to the provisions of Article V of the Constitution, there shall be held a plebiscite on Friday, April thirty, nineteen hundred and thirty-seven, on the question of woman suffrage. On said date all qualified women, as hereinafter provided, may vote either in favor or against the granting of such suffrage.

Said Article V of the Constitution shall be published in the Official Gazette, in English and in Spanish, for three consecutive issues at least fifteen days prior to said election, and the said Article V shall be posted in a conspicuous place in each municipal and provincial office building and in each polling place not later than the twenty-second day of April, nineteen hundred and thirty-seven, and shall remain posted therein continually until after the termination of the plebiscite. At least ten copies of the said Article V of the Constitution, in English and in Spanish, shall be kept at each polling place available for examination by the qualified electors during the plebiscite. Whenever practicable, copies in the principal native languages as may be determined by the Secretary of the Interior, shall also be kept in each polling place.

Section 2

Every female citizen of the Philippines, twenty-one years of age, or over, who shall have been a resident of the Philippines for one year and of the municipality wherein she proposes to vote for at least six months next preceding the plebiscite and who possesses the qualifications required by existing law for male voters, but without the disqualifications therein specified, is entitled to vote in said plebiscite.

Section 8

The ballots to be used in the plebiscite shall be printed in English and in Spanish and shall conform to the following form:

(Commonwealth seal)

OFFICIAL BALLOT

BALOTA OFICIAL

THE QUESTION OF WOMAN SUFFRAGE is submitted in this plebiscite to the female citizens of the Philippines, in order that they may vote either in favor or against the granting of such suffrage pursuant to the provisions of Article V of the Constitution which reads as follows:

"SECTION 1. Suffrage may be exercised by male citizens of the Philippines not otherwise disqualified by law, who are twenty-one years of age or over and are able to read and write, and who shall have resided in the Philippines for one year and in the municipality wherein they propose to vote for at least six months preceding the election. The National Assembly shall extend the right of suffrage to women, if in a plebiscite which shall be held for that purpose within two years after the adoption of this Constitution, not less than three hundred thousand women possessing the necessary qualifications shall vote affirmatively on the question."

If you are in favor of woman suffrage answer "Yes," and if you are against, answer "No" in the corresponding square.

LA CUESTION DEL SUFRAGIO FEMENINO se somete en este plebiscito a las ciudadanas de Filipinas para que ellas voten, bien a favor o en contra del otorgamiento de dicho sufragio, por virtud de las disposiciones del Capitulo V de la Constitucion que se lee como sigue:

"ARTICULO 1. Podra ejercitar el sufragio todo ciudadano filipino que tenga veintiun años de edad o mas, sepa leer o escribir, haya residido en Filipinas un año, y seis meses, por lo menos, en el municipio en que se proponga votar antes de la fecha de la eleccion, y que de otro modo no este incapacitado por la ley. La Asamblea Nacional otorgara, sin embargo, a la mujer el derecho de sufragio, siempre que, en un plebiscito que se convocara al efecto, dentro de dos años despues de la adoptada esta Constitucion, trescientas mil mujeres cuando menos, que poseyeran las necesarias calificaciones, voten afirmativamente sobre la cuestion."

Si está en favor del otorgamiento de dicho sufragio, escriba la palabra "Si" en el encasillado en blanco despues de la pregunta: si está en contra, escriba la palabra "No." SECcIH

Are you in favor of granting suffrage to women?

¿Está Vd. en favor de la concesion del sufragio a las mujeres?

Section 10A A count of the votes cast according to the returns of the board of inspectors will be made by the National Assembly. If the result shows that not less than three hundred thousand women have voted affirmatively on the question, all women who possess the qualifications specified in section two hereof will be entitled to vote in any election which may be held thereafter. In such case, the registration list of the plebiscite may be used in any subsequent election, until revised according to law

**COMMONWEALTH ACT NO.
444
EIGHT HOUR LABOR LAW**

In an attempt to keep his promise during his campaign, Manuel Quezon as President of the Commonwealth government proclaimed a program of social justice in 1936. Through this program, he intended to help the Filipinos particularly the landless peasants and the exploited laborers. In response, the National Assembly enacted social justice measures aimed at the underprivileged.

From 1936-1941, the Commonwealth government enacted a number of laws for the protection of peasants and workers. One of these was the Commonwealth Act No. 444 or the Eight-Hour Labor Law which stipulates a maximum of eight working hours a day for laborers "employed in any industry or occupation, whether public or private, with the exception of farm laborer, laborers who prefer to be paid on piece work basis, domestic servants and persons in the personal service of another and members of the family of the employer working for him." The law also states that additional 25 percent of his pay should be given if the person worked on Sundays and legal holidays. The act further provided that, "In case of national emergency the Government is empowered to establish rules and regulations for the operation of the plants and factories and to determine the wages to be paid the laborers."

EXCERPT:

Section 1. The legal working day for any person employed by another shall be of not more than eight hours daily. When the work is not continuous, the time during which the laborer is not working and can leave his working place and can rest completely shall not be counted.

Section 2. This Act shall apply to all persons employed in any industry or occupation, whether public or private, with the exception of farm laborers, laborers who prefer to be paid on piece work basis, domestic servants and persons in the personal service of another and members of the family of the employer working for him.

Section 3. Work may be performed beyond eight hours a day in case of actual or impending emergencies caused by serious accidents, fire, flood, typhoon, earthquake, epidemic, or other disaster or calamity in order to prevent loss of life and property or imminent danger to public safety; or in case of urgent work to be performed on the machine, equipment, or installations in order to avoid a serious loss which the employer would otherwise suffer, or some other just cause of a similar nature; but in all such cases the laborers and employees shall be entitled to receive compensation for the overtime work performed at the same rate as their regular wages or salary, plus at least twenty-five per centum additional.

In case of national emergency the Government is empowered to establish rules and regulations for the operation of the plants and factories and to determine the wages to be paid the laborers.

Section 4. No person, firm, or corporation, business establishment or place or center of labor shall compel an employee or laborer to work during Sundays and legal holidays, unless he is paid an additional sum of at least twenty-five per centum of his regular remuneration: Provided however, That this prohibition shall not apply to public utilities performing some public service such as supplying gas, electricity, power, water, or providing means of transportation or communication.

Section 5. Exemption from the provisions of sections two, and three hereof may be granted by the Secretary of labor in the interest of the public, or if, in his opinion, such exemption is justifiable either because the organization or nature of the work requires it, or because of lack or insufficiency of competent laborers in a locality or because the relieving of laborers must be done under certain conditions, or by reason of any other exceptional circumstances or conditions of the work or industry concerned; but when such exemption is granted employees and laborers will be paid at least twenty-five per centum in addition to their regular salaries or wages for the time in excess of eight hours.

Section 6. Any agreement or contract between the employer and the laborer or employee contrary to the provisions of this Act shall be null and void ab initio.

Section 7. Any violation of this Act by the employer or person having direct control and supervision over the work shall be punished by a fine of not more than one thousand pesos, or by imprisonment for not more than one year, or both.

Section 8. Acts Numbered Forty-one hundred and twenty-three and Forty-two hundred and forty-two of the former Philippine Legislature are repealed.

Section 9. This Act shall take effect upon its approval.

APPROVED: June 3, 1939.

Inauguration Committee. *Inauguration of the Commonwealth of the Philippines (Schedule of Events)*. Manila: Bureau of Printing. November 2-30, 1935.

Published by the Inauguration Committee of the Commonwealth of the Philippines, this document details the daily activities of the government officials and other guests of the Commonwealth inauguration from November 2 to 30, 1935. Among the most distinguished guests were Hon. George H. Dern, US Secretary of War and the personal representative of the US President, Vice President John N. Garner and Speaker Joseph Byrns. A complete list of the Congressional and press delegations and other special guests is found in this schedule of events. It also includes a copy of the program during the inauguration of the Commonwealth of the Philippines on November 15, 1935 and the daily activities of government officials including conferences, sight-seeing and private engagements.

This document is an important primary source for students and researchers interested particularly about the history of the Commonwealth Government of the Philippines.

Excerpt:

FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 15, 1935

INAUGURATION CEREMONIES

Place: Legislative Building

The Secretary of War and the Governor-General will

drive together from Malacañan Palace to the Inauguration Ceremonies preceded by a Cavalry escort.

The President-elect will drive with his family from

his residence in Pasay to the Inauguration Ceremonies preceded by a Cavalry escort.

7. *IO a. m.*- Assemblage at the Legislative Building. The rear doors will be opened to Officials and distinguished Guests.

7.40 *a. m.*-Assemblage at the Grandstand.

Wives of all the Officials and distinguished Guests as well as all other persons invited to attend the Inauguration Ceremonies will occupy the places respectively assigned to them before 7.40 a. M.

7.45 *a. m.*-Entrance of Officials and Distinguished Guests.

8. *IO a. m.*-Entrance of the Governor-General, the President-elect and the Secretary of War.

8. *I 5 a. m.*-- Inaugural Ceremonies.

Invocation by His Grace, the , Most Reverend Gabriel M. Reyes, D. D., Archbishop of Cebu.

Introduction of the Secretary of War by the Governor-General.
Address by the Secretary of War.

Reading by the Governor-General of the President's proclamation.

Administration of the Oath of Office to the President-elect by the Chief Justice of the Supreme Court.

Administration of the Oath of Office to the Vice President-elect by the Chief Justice of the Supreme Court.

Administration of the Oath of Office to the Members-elect of the National Assembly by the Chief Justice of the Supreme Court.

Declaration by the Secretary of War that the Government of the Commonwealth of the Philippines has been established.

8.45 *a.m.*-Inaugural Address by His Excellency Manuel L. Quezon, President of the Philippines.

9.00 a. m.- Recession.

Upon the conclusion of the inauguration ceremonies, the following will withdraw into the Chamber of the former House of Representatives in the following order:

The President of the Philippines .

The United States High Commissioner.

The Secretary of War of the United States.

End of the Ceremonies.

Departure of the High Commissioner under escort.

Departure of the Secretary of War under escort.

Departure of other officials and distinguished Guests who may not desire to remain for the parade.

9.30 a. m.-Inaugural Parade:

A bugle call will be sounded to indicate

the start of the parade from Plaza Lawton.

At the proper time the President will return to the ceremonial Stand, step up on the platform in front of the Presidential flag and review the parade.

The other Officials and distinguished Guests who may have retired into the Chamber of the former House of Representatives may return to their respective places in the Ceremonial Stand to watch the parade.

ORDER OF UNITS

Grand Marshall:

Brig. Gen. Basilio J. Valdes, Chief of the Philippine Constabulary.

Military Parade--

United States Army.

Philippine Constabulary. Philippine Coastguard Service. University of the Philippines Corps of Cadets.

Ateneo de Manila Corps of Cadets.

San Juan de Letran Corps of Cadets.

Civic Parade-

Provincial Delegations.

Manila and Baguio Delegations. Municipal Delegations.

Commercial and Industrial Units .

Labor Unions.

Miscellaneous Units.

Upon the completion of the parade, the President will proceed to Malacañan Palace preceded by a cavalry escort.

Outside the gates of Malacañan, the cavalry escort will be

relieved by the Palace Guard which will escort the President anew and

precede him on his entry into the Palace.

12.30 p. m.-Official call on the President by:

The Vice President of the Philippines

The Speaker and Members of the National Assembly

The Chief Justice and Associate Justices of the Supreme Court.

The Members of the Cabinet.

Place: Malacañan Palace

4:00 p. m.-Opening session of the National Assembly.

Place: Chamber of the former House of Representatives

7.30 p. m.- Fireworks display .

Place: Manila Bay in front of the New Luneta .

8.00 p. m.- Dinner given by the President and

Mrs. Quezon in honor of the Secretary of War and Mrs. Dern.

Place: Home of President Quezon, Pasay.

9.30 p. M.- Inaugural Ball—Pageant depicting epochs, 1898-1935.

Admission by ticket , proceeds for charity.

Place: Inaugural Auditorium, Wallace Field.

**Quezon, Manuel. "My loyalty to my party ends where my loyalty to my country begins."
Speech delivered at the Colectivista Party Convention. Manila, Grand Opera House.
1922.**

The 1922 legislative elections was an important event in the history of Philippine politics. This is particularly because of the internal conflict that caused a split in the *Partido Nacionalista*, the ruling political party in Philippine Legislature since 1907. The conflict was mainly between the leadership of Sergio Osmeña in the House of Representatives and Manuel Quezon in the Senate.

The famous split was announced on February 17, 1922 when the newly-formed party, the *Partido Nacionalista-Colectivista* introduced Quezon as its president. It is in this party convention that Manuel Quezon delivered this speech saying that the "disagreement in the party.. is due to nothing else but a difference in opinion that grew wider as days went by." He also emphasized the importance of saving one's principles even if it means sacrificing "everything, even the party itself." The split resulted to the defeat of the Nacionalistas in the legislative elections on June 6, 1922.

This document is an important reference on Quezon's political life, on the history of the *Partido Nacionalista* and in the history of Philippine politics.

EXCERPT:

My loyalty to my party ends where my loyalty to my country begins

This is a day of transcendental importance to me. I am going to take a step the consequences of which I have foreseen, out the result of which God alone knows. From the time I entered public life I fought under the banner of the Nationalism Party. I affiliated with it at a time when the only words written on its flag were: Immediate Independence. I affiliated with it when the struggle we carried on during the revolution was still fresh in my mind and I thought it my solemn duty to form part of a political organization to defend the very same ideals for which the soldiers of the Revolution fought and fell.

The Nacionalista Party and the entire Filipino people know how faithfully I have served my party colleagues. Everybody knows how I fought for them within and without the ranks and that I never hesitated to come to the fore to defend the party's ideals and its men. I want to recall at this moment, with satisfaction and without regret, how I have always supported and defended hints with all sincerity and even as strongly as his strongest supporters could have done. I defended the party at least as much as the staunchest Nacionalista and the most dyed-in the wool Unipersonalist.

But the party never has been and never will be the people. My loyalty to my party ends where my loyalty to my country begins. Even if it were not the Nationalism Party, let it be any other party, from the moment that my convictions do not coincide with the ideal For which the party stands, I consider it my duty to leave it. A man to be worthy of the name should put his conviction into practice, profess them with faith, defend them with courage, happen what may.

My colleagues of the Nationalism party know that rumor has been spread and broadcast that the disagreement in the party is due to personal ambitions, jealousies and envies. Those who are more intimately linked with the march of events know full well that it is due to nothing else but a difference in opinion that grew wider as days went by.

I did not look for the conflict. The conflict was thrust on me. A recent arrival from the United States, the Filipino people know that I *had* to undergo medical treatment, that my health was broken, that I needed rest. I tried to avoid it because I knew that it was going to mean a fight, and I did not want conflict, I wanted harmony, peace.

The conflict came in spite of myself. Confronted by it, I had to defend the principles which I sincerely believed were just. After the reorganization of the Lower House, on a more liberal basis than it has ever been in the past, I invited peace. I was answered that the fight has not ended. On another occasion again I asked for peace, and again I was answered that the fight was on, and then I was told that the issue was going to be presented to the convention and that those who shall refuse to abide by the decision of the majority shall be expelled from the party.

You will agree with me, gentlemen, that those who believe with me in the principles of collective leadership because it is their honest conviction were not going to retreat nor surrender. It was a question of principle and conviction and there is no pity on earth that can make them change their views.

The convention met. The principles of the collective group were accepted. They were accepted so as to avoid the split, a split that at first they wanted to force but Mach Lee they exerted all efforts to prevent.

The independence question was brought forward as argument against the reorganization of a new party. Resignations were tendered. Sacrifices were offered or made in order to maintain the union in the party. The collective theory of leadership and other collective propositions were accepted and incorporated at the party platform. Nothing was taken advantage of for the sake of the unity of the party. Ideas and principles were sacrificed. The motto of the Unipersonalists was: *Sacrifice all principles, but save the party at all cost!* The motto of the Collectivists is: *Save the principles and sacrifice everything, even the party itself!*

We did not look for the division. I did not favor the split. But it exists now, fatal to the country, perhaps, but necessary for the health of the country. My Collectivist colleagues know how much I tried to avoid this conflict especially so when the collective principles were accepted by the Unipersonalists. I was opposed to a division in the party. That is why you must have noticed how the papers spoke of union one day and the next day of a possible split, union the next and a division the following day and so on.

The positive fact is that nobody can prevent the split in the Nacionalista Party. It is divided because men who were once united, now disagree on fundamental questions that vitally affect the country. While some are *conservatives*, others are liberal. *and while* some are

Unipersonalists others are Collectivists. The Nacionalista Party might have incorporated the collective principles but this was because those who are in it saw that it as the only salvation for its men, during the coming elections. The one who over A month ago was *an out-and-out* Unipersonalist and overnight mined a complete somersault and changed into a Collectivists, cannot profess that faith with sincerity. It is a conviction for convenience, and it cannot and should not be taken at its face value.

It is said that there is no difference between the Unipersonal and Collective theories. It is a question of mere form, they say. The Unipersonalist who thinks that the present conflicting tendencies are not a sufficient foundation to differentiate one from the other does not either understand the real question at issue or in accepting the Collective principles, accepted them inching sincerity The difference is fundamental

The Collectivists believe in a true government of democracy, not only in form, but also in fact, not the people's rule without the expression of popular will, but a government by the people by means of a voluntary expression of the sovereign will of that people. The Collectivists want a government of opinion, not a government that solves questions without the country's knowledge or how or when the solution was made.

One of the greatest arguments used against us by our American critics is that we do not have here a government of opinion. But is that a more conclusive proof of the fact that there is public opinion here than the present triumph of the Collective principle of leadership? Is there one who doubts that this question has already been decided by the people? When this question was dismissed for the first time, almost all the papers, with very few exceptions, were in favor of the unipersonal theory and against the collective principle. What was the effect on the people? Nothing, absolutely nothing. The people decided for themselves. And this shows beyond the shadow of a doubt that here we have public opinion, courageous, independent, unbiased. Those who followed this question with interest must have seen that the Filipino people is interested in matters that vitally affect its government, and that is capable of forming its own opinion, without the need of tutors or mentors. I repeat, the entire press of the Philippines was against the collective principle, and when I say press, I refer specially to the so-called independent papers. and yet the country declared itself in favor of Collectivism, and such is the force of the avalanche that the Unipersonalists are afraid to own that they are what they say.

The question now is: after the acceptance and inclusion of the collective theory in the Nacionalista platform, should we remain in the party? I have given this subject much thought. I spent sleepless nights pondering over it and this I say in all the seriousness that step such as the one were taking deserves. There are those who believe and affirm that personal ambition and personal interest are the main consideration in the fight. They said that the one who will head it is there, because he wants to scale the heights of power, and that those who follow him do it not because of principles, but for personal convenience. In all sincerity I want to tell you now that

lest our action be translated in that thwarted way, and there are many who are interested in presenting it thus, I tried my very best to prevent the split because I do not want that political struggles in this country should be taken as animated by personal motives.

Listen to this: The politician who does not have any patriotic purpose but his personal aggrandizement in entering politics, who is only after personal convenience and nothing else is surely after a job, a position. Can I find a position in the Philippine Government and in the gift of the Filipino people higher than that of President of the Senate, the highest position to which a Filipino could be sent by his countrymen? If I wanted to perpetuate myself in power, is there anything better for me than to remain in the Nacionalista Party?

But no! I prefer to take the risky side. I prefer to be in a new party that must be organized, that will mean sacrifice, work, fight. And the same is true with those who are with me. There is nothing more comfortable for them than to remain a powerful party to ensure their victory at the polls. But they sustain a principle. They are fighting for their conviction, not for their convenience. One should not belong to a party only to occupy a position so that he may better defend the ideals of the party by means of his position.

There are no bad feelings against our former colleagues of the Nacionalista Party. We harbor no grudge against them. We give them the same affection. There is no reason in the world why we cannot consider ourselves as brothers. Unless they consider that only who belong to one party can be called brothers, and if that is their conception of unity on a party, I say that is destructive, suicidal. It is not the unity of the party that should be sought. It should rather be the unity of the people. Partisan struggles should never involve bad feelings and personal hatred. We can and we should remain as we have been, the brothers that we are.

What a beautiful spectacle for the country to behold political fights limited to discussion of principles eliminating personalities! What a magnificent spectacle for the people to see political opponents eating on the same banquet tables, united by the same links of affection and friendship! Much as I regret it, this seems to be something unknown yet here. Everytime that the people saw the Speaker and myself together, immediately the talk goes the rounds that our political differences have been patched up. When we had toasted each other at a banquet in the Ayuntamiento. All the papers said there was peace between the two, not knowing that the next day a big bomb is going to explode.

People may ask why it is that this break only takes place now. The reason is simple. When the Nacionalista Party was organized, it was an organization with the sole purpose of coordinating the forces of the country together for Philippine Independence. It was not called upon to solve political, social, economic matters. All the Filipinos affiliated as Nacionalistas; in time the Nacionalista Party came into power. It found itself then confronted by political, social, and economic problems. It was invested with legislative power. From that time on differences in

opinion began to spring up. You must have noticed that our Senate is liberal and our Lower House, conservative. This is the only country where such a phenomenon takes place with the exception of Australia. The reason is simple and it needs no further comment. That fact exists. There are two tendencies, the conservative and the liberal, and it is for the welfare of the country that there should be two parties organized and based on those opposing tendencies.

Laws do not make a government democratic or autocratic or have autocratic laws and have democratic government. We have England for example where there is a king and it is a monarchy, yet the workings of its government are democratic. And we have: on the other hand some Latin American countries where their government can be summarized in three points: 1. The government resides in the people; 2. The people delegate their power to a President; 3. The President does what he pleases.

I want to tell you, gentlemen, that we have done all that we could to avoid this split. Our efforts failed, the Collectivists believe that union in a party does not mean union of men. It means unity in principles professed and practised. We believe that the organization of a new party does not mean the bankruptcy of our National cause, because we hold the Nacionalista Party is not the people. Even if there is a split, we shall work together for our complete political emancipation. We have faith in our people, blind, sublime faith in them and we know that no Filipino will be recreant to the legacy bequeathed to him by his forefathers and that all of us to a man will stand in favor of Philippine Independence, immediate, absolute and complete. We know that the Filipino people, irrespective of party, creed, or religion, will force the issue and compel all party men to work for the realization of our sacred ideals.

We divided, but divided in ideas, united in sentiment, united in love of country, divided in the procedure of serving her best. The Unipersonalists are antiquarians: the Collectivists are modern. Even if I wanted to remain in the party, I cannot very well do it. For it would be like mixing oil and water in a glass. We shall need a new house now that we leave our old one. Now we have two strong parties that our hope shall fight ideals and ideals alone, eliminating personalities.

Speech of Senate President Manuel Quezon accepting his nomination as President of the Philippines, July 20, 1935.

Source:<https://www.officialgazette.gov.ph/1935/07/20/speech-of-senate-president-manuel-quezon-accepting-his-nomination-as-president-of-the-philippines/>

This excerpt is from the speech delivered by Manuel L. Quezon, who was serving as then Senate President in June 1935, and accepting his nomination as President of the Philippines by his political party, Nacionalista Party. His running mate, then Senator Sergio Osmena. Both Quezon and Osmena were rivals in securing the passage of a law in the US Congress for Philippine Independence. Quezon eventually won. He defeated former President Emilio Aguinaldo and bishop Gregorio Aglipay of the Philippine Independent Catholic Church in the elections held in September of the same year.

His speech provided his platform of governance and key programs pertaining to issues such as economy, education, infrastructure, relations with the United States, foreign relations, and independence. This excerpt shows the issues on administration of justice and social problems, warning that these issues may be used to stir-up discontent among the masses. This issue of social unrest and discontent among the masses was evidently seen in the Sakdal uprising that year.

**Speech
of
Senate President Manuel L. Quezon
Accepting his nomination as President of the Philippines**

[Delivered on July 20, 1935]

Mr. CHAIRMAN, GENTLEMEN OF THE COMMITTEE, FELLOW-CITIZENS:

It is with a profound sense of gratitude that I received in the presence of this vast multitude the formal notification of my nomination for the Presidency of the Commonwealth. A party nomination for the highest office within the gift of the people is in itself a great distinction, but when the nomination comes under such auspicious circumstances as have attended that which is now proffered to me, I regard it as the greatest honor that can be accorded to any public man short alone of his actual election to the Presidency.

Ever since the approval and acceptance of the Independence Act there has been growing among the people a feeling of deepest concern over the difficult problems and impending responsibilities which will confront us upon the inauguration of the Commonwealth. While the

Constitutional Convention was in session, partly fostered by the spirit of national solidarity exhibited by the members of that body, the anxiety to prepare the country adequately to meet these problems and responsibilities became articulate in an increasingly popular demand for national unity, that political parties give pause to partisan strife, that the leaders of the vital forces of the nation join in their efforts for the attainment of the common goal, and that the entire country resolve to support loyally the man who may be entrusted with the national leadership so that through the Government of the Commonwealth the foundations of the future Philippine Republic may be solidly and firmly established.

Resolutions were passed by municipal councils as well as by civic and social organizations, including labor unions, demanding a coalition of the two great political parties as the most practical means of obtaining this unity of effort. Before the Constitutional Convention adjourned the cry of national unity was taken up by the League of Provincial Governors Without regard to party affiliation and voicing the prevailing sentiment in their respective provinces, these spokesmen of our local governments unanimously joined in the general appeal for unity.

Lastly, prominent Filipino business men, professionals and leaders in agriculture, industry, and labor formally submitted to the directorate of the two political parties a concrete proposal that the two parties nominate jointly the candidates for President and Vice President and thus insure the cooperation of all the vital forces of the nation during the first and trying the years of the Commonwealth. When the two parties held their respective national conventions they readily responded to this popular clamor and forthwith agreed to form a coalition and to nominate the same candidates for President and Vice President.

Neither Senator Osmeña nor I sought these nominations. We made no preconvention campaign nor did we have any desire to secure them. We entered public life about the same time thirty years ago both pledged to the cause of independence. The vicissitudes which have been our lot during these years are not now to be recounted but as I look back upon our joint efforts in the attainment of the goal which we set out before us I feel happy that at the end of the long struggle we can face our people standing on the same platform, our pledge fulfilled, our mutual friendship and regard enhanced, and still enjoying, I hope, their continued confidence and support.

With the approval of the Independence Act and its acceptance by the country we believed that our extended public service could at last come to an end. We would have been content as private citizens to lend our unstinted support to the new Government. But it seems that our fellow-citizens have once again chosen to place upon our shoulders the new responsibility of organizing the Commonwealth and leading the nation during the early years of its existence. The nomination that has been proffered to us attains the category of a call to duty which no public-spirited citizen may evade or disregard. I, therefore, Mr. Chairman, make public announcement that I accept the nomination for the Presidency which has been tendered to me, deeming it my bounden duty to do so, and I accept it with the most profound sense of the responsibility that it entails and the deepest feeling of gratitude.

Having been nominated under the circumstances I have mentioned, I cannot afford to speak in uncertain terms. The need of the hour is for fixed orientation, clear statement of policies, and a definition of the national purposes. In the course of the present campaign I shall have the opportunity to discuss all the important questions before the country. For the present I have to limit myself to a few of them.

THE PLATFORM

The Coalition platform meets with my wholehearted approval. I took part in the drafting of that document and I make my own every commitment contained therein.

THE CONSTITUTION

I look upon the Constitution of the Philippines as the expression of the sovereignty and of the aggregate will of the Filipino people. I shall abide by its provisions. I shall uphold the democratic principle underlying the institutions that it establishes. I am opposed to a dictatorship. I maintain that no man who believes in a dictatorship can with safety be entrusted with the reins of executive power under our Constitution. Democracy can only survive if those at the helm of the Government believe in the people's right to rule and have faith in their inherent capacity to decide rightly important public questions.

I will hold inviolate and will defend to the utmost the individual rights and liberties. I shall safeguard free speech, the freedom of the press, and the equality of every man before the law however poor or ignorant. I shall insure for every citizen of the Philippines, from Luzon to Mindanao and Sulu, the right to worship God as his own conscience dictates.

THE GOVERNMENT OF THE COMMONWEALTH

We are entering a new era. We are on the threshold of free nationhood. The Government of the Commonwealth that we shall establish derives its powers from a constitution approved by the people themselves. It may truly be said that it is a government of our creation to be administered for our own welfare.

Except in a few specified cases, it will be free from American control in the conduct of domestic affairs. Only in our foreign relations do we remain subject to American supervision, and this because of the continuing responsibility of the foreign aggression during the life of the Commonwealth. Hence, the Government of the Commonwealth will be, in fact not in name, an independent government under the protection of the United States.

The immediate task before us is to set up the new Government,—a task that will require all the foresight, the wisdom, and the courage of the people. Then we must adopt such measures as will insure the stability of our national economy, and provide for the honest and efficient administration of the affairs of the government. Equally important is to make adequate provision for the defense of our country against external aggression or internal disorders.

I favor a simple and economical government, one in keeping with the limited resources of our country but which is capable of ministering to the needs of the nations.

I shall be unsparing in my efforts to carry out the mandate of the Constitution regarding the civil service. Merit and character alone will be the qualification for office or promotion. For the highest responsible posts I shall call on the most capable, honest, and patriotic citizens, regardless of political affiliation or religious belief. This is no time for placing party considerations above the common weal. In fact, one of the main purposes of the coalition is to secure the cooperation and help of the best available men to insure the success of the Commonwealth. I shall tolerate neither corruption nor inefficiency in public office.

FINANCIAL POLICY

The financial stability of the Government depends upon our ability to keep expenses within our income. At the time when other governments are resorting to loans in order to meet their obligations we can take pride in the fact that we have been able to maintain a balanced budget. Under our Constitution the responsibility for maintaining a balanced budget falls mainly upon the executive. I pledge myself to maintain the credit of the Government and at all times to balance the budget and keep our finances in a sound condition.

I shall keep our present currency system in all its integrity and will allow no change that will affect its value. If new conditions should require such a change it will be done only after the most careful study and consultation with competent experts. For the present I can see no reason for any radical modification in our monetary system.

TAXATION

Irresponsible demagogues have tried to arouse in the hearts of our people the hope that under an independent Philippines there shall be no taxes except upon the rich. It is my duty to warn the credulous against such misrepresentation. Governments can be supported only through taxation. It is a primary duty of citizens to contribute to the support of the Government, but taxation that does not take into consideration the relative financial ability of the taxpayer is unjust. I favor a complete revision of our system of taxation with the best technical advice available. I advocate that the burdens of the state be equitably disputed in proportion to the means and possibilities of the taxpayer. We shall make a general reduction of the assessed value of real property in accordance with present prices.

PUBLIC WORKS

The so-called pork barrel system, as known in the United States and as sometimes practiced in the Philippines, must definitely be discarded. It is a waste of public funds. I am in favor of continuing the building of roads and schools, in accordance with a carefully-prepared plan to be followed systematically in the order of their relative importance to the general public.

PUBLIC INSTRUCTION

I stand by the educational policy enunciated in the Constitution. The principle underlying this policy is the training for useful, well-disciplined, self sacrificing citizenship that draws its breath of life from Filipino patriotism. Our system of education should be revised so as to accomplish that aim still more effectively. The State is in duty bound to maintain a complete and adequate system of public education, providing at least free public primary instruction and citizenship training to adult citizens.

My attention will be especially devoted to making it possible for every child to go to school. Adult citizenship training will be carried out in accordance with a broad and systematic plan. To the end that poverty may not prevent gifted young men and women from developing their talent, the Government should create the largest possible number of scholarships for them in all branches of learning. Our educational objective should fit in with our economic policy. I am for greater emphasis on vocational and agricultural training in the intermediate and high schools, but the instruction should always be in keeping with the economic conditions of each region and of the country as a whole.

ADMINISTRATION OF JUSTICE

An independent judiciary administering justice without fear or favor promptly and impartially to rich and poor alike is the strongest bulwark of individual rights and the best guaranty against oppression and usurpation from any source. Equally important is the maintenance of the confidence of the people in the courts. I will appoint no man to the bench without having satisfied myself, after a thorough investigation, of his character and ability.

To strengthen the faith of the common people in our courts, it is necessary that the utmost care be exerted in the selection of justices of the peace. These courts are often the only tribunals accessible to the larger portion of our population and it is essential that they be maintained Worthy of their confidence. If the disinherited cannot obtain redress of their grievances or vindication of their rights in these courts, they have no further recourse, for the Courts of First Instance and the Supreme Court are often beyond their reach. By the impartiality and integrity of the justices of the peace, therefore, the judiciary of the Philippines is judged by the millions of our countrymen who live in the barrios and distant places. I pledge myself to do everything in my power to maintain these courts free from political or other extraneous influence and to appoint thereto only men of proven ability and integrity and of the broadest human sympathies.

SOCIAL PROBLEMS

The welfare of the people should be the concern of the Government. The helpless and the needy, the jobless, as well as the workers in the factories and in the field have a claim upon the Government to safeguard their health and well-being. The contentment of the masses is the first insurance against social and political disorders. It is the duty of the Government to protect the working men against social and political disorders. It is the duty and exploitation to secure to them fair wages and return for their labor.

Let us beware of men who deliberately, for political or selfish aims, stir up discontent among the masses. They preach subversive doctrines, speak of evils and abuses that do not exist, or magnify those which often are inevitable in democracies. These men are those worse enemies of society, more dangerous to the community than ordinary criminals. They have no sympathy for the people, but are mere self-seekers, intent only in securing either pecuniary or political advantage for themselves. If as a result of their preaching disorders occur, they cowardly disclaim all responsibility for that which none other than themselves had brought about. He who tries to carry favor with the masses by appealing to the passions of the people, stirring up their prejudices, or capitalizing discontent or human suffering, is unworthy of public trust.

LANDED ESTATES

The ownership of big landed estates by corporations or absentee landlords have invariably caused discontent and unrest among the tenants or occupants of such estates. The discontent among the tenants of the Friar lands contributed to the causes which led to the rebellion against Spain. Those Friar lands have been acquired by the Government and sold in small lots but there are still a few large haciendas particularly in Luzon that are the hotbeds of discontent and unrest among their tenants. Not only for the sake of these tenants, but also in the interest of peace, every effort should be made to acquire these haciendas, at a fair and just price to be sold in small lots to the tenants.

There are complaints in certain places that the tenants are the victims of unfair practices on the part of their landlords. These abuses must be stopped and the tenant protected in his rights.

LABOR

Fortunately for our country, we have had no sharp cleavages between labor and capital. Strikes have been few and far-between, and they have never been long-drawn-out or general. That we have so far been spared the extremities of class warfare, is no proof that we shall forever be exempt. Our good fortune should rather teach us to seek the means to preserve the country against such conflicts by the only method which experience has shown to be effective; namely, by taking steps designed to prevent the exploitation and oppression of the working men and thus assure their happiness and contentment.

Filipino laborers, compared to those of other oriental countries, receive higher wages and are much better protected in their rights by legislation. We have enacted many laws protecting labor. In all earnestness, however, I must say that we must go further in this direction. The experience of centuries shows that the one sure way to protect society against class war is to secure to wage-earners their due.

I am against communism. I am a firm believer in the institution of private property. I contend, however, that whenever property rights come in conflict with human rights, the former should yield to the latter.

If we would preserve the institution of private property, we must hold fast to this principle, in the determination of conflicting rights between man and man. It is thus that we may draw the line between the rights of labor and capital and erect an economic structure based on the Principle that human life is the measure of all other values, that considerations of possession and profit must give way to the supremacy of human existence.

CAPITAL

A change in the political status of a country always gives rise to fear and misgivings. Not only among Americans and foreigners, but even among a few Filipinos, the impending political changes have caused anxiety as to the future.

There is no justification for these fears. I give assurance that peace, order, law and justice will reign supreme under the Commonwealth, and that the rights of foreigners and nationals alike will be safeguarded. Existing investments, whether foreign or national, will receive every inducement to stay, and outside capital will be welcomed. We especially desire that new American capital should come and help in the development of the country.

NATIONAL DEFENSE

I believe in the efficacy of the instrumentalities of peace, such as the League of Nations or treaties of neutrality. In due time we should apply for admission to the League and urge the negotiation of a multilateral treaty for the neutralization of the Philippines. However, we cannot ignore present-day realities. We cannot rely exclusively on these implements of peace for our national defense.

I favor preparedness for national defense. We cannot afford to have, nor do I approve of, a large standing army or costly military establishments, but we must have a regular army of sufficient size for our requirements and a trained citizenry ready to be drafted into service in any emergency. For the proper planning of our defenses and organization and training of our regular and citizen army I shall secure the best expert advice.

OUR RELATIONS WITH AMERICA

It should be our constant endeavor to maintain the most friendly relations and closest collaboration with the United States. We owe much to America and we are grateful to her. Our present economy is tied up with the free American market. Many of our industries depend for their existence on our reciprocal free trade relations with the United States, and we should try to maintain these trade relations if possible, even after independence. I shall spare no effort to obtain the elimination of the export tax provided in the Independence Law. I shall work for the repeal of the excise tax on coconut oil. I shall endeavor to take such action as may be required to place our trade relations with the United States on a truly reciprocal basis, so that they may be continued after independence for the mutual advantage of both countries.

FOREIGN RELATIONS

As already stated, our foreign relations will be under the control and supervision of the United States during the Commonwealth; but there is nothing in the Independence Act which prevents the Commonwealth from beginning to lay the foundations for our future relations with foreign nations. Indeed, the period of transition having been provided to give to the Filipino people time to prepare themselves for the responsibilities of an independent government, it can be rightly assumed that the United States meant to give us the opportunity, under the Commonwealth of initiating both political as well as trade relations with other countries, subject to its supervision and control.

We shall request the State Department at Washington to permit the Commonwealth to send men as attaches to American legations or embassies as well as to American consulates in order that these men may acquire the knowledge and experience in the diplomatic service and provide our government with needed information concerning foreign trade.

It will be necessary and to our advantage besides to win the good-will of, and maintain friendly relations with, other nations. But to accomplish this aim, mere protestations of good purposes are not enough. We must deal fairly with all nations and respect their rights. We must secure to every foreigner who lives with us full protection of our laws. His life, his property, must be as safe among us as they are in his own land.

During the transition period we shall endeavor to find new markets for our products so that if and when the market of the United States shall no longer be open to us except on a competitive basis, we may not be left without outlet for our products.

PHILIPPINE INDEPENDENCE

The question of Philippine Independence has been settled. The Independence Law sets the day for independence and prescribes the process leading to its consummation. We accepted the Independence Law, we have approved a Constitution pursuant to its provisions, and the people by ratifying it with practical unanimity have agreed to the grant of independence under the terms and conditions prescribed by the Congress. Independence, therefore, is no longer an issue either in the United States or in the Philippines. Insofar as the terms and conditions of independence are concerned, we made it plain when we accepted the Independence Law that we reserved the right to petition Congress for their modification with a view to making them less burdensome for our people and more adapted to the attainment of the purpose for which Congress intended them.

We consider the economic provisions of the Independence Law not entirely fair to the Philippines. We regard legislation recently passed by Congress imposing greater restrictions on our free imports to the United States or authorizing the collection of exorbitant taxes on some of our products sold in that country, not only discriminatory, but a virtual violation of the solemn covenant between the two countries. We shall exert every effort to secure the repeal of those discriminatory measures and to obtain amendments to the Independence Law looking to a more equitable trade arrangement between the United States and the Philippines during the Commonwealth.

In relation to the transition period, the Congress of the United States fixed the term of ten years considering it necessary to allow the Philippines gradually to adjust their national economy to the conditions which will obtain when independence should eventuate and to permit the Filipinos to prepare themselves adequately for the responsibilities of independent nationhood. It was, therefore, chiefly for the benefit of the Philippines, rather than of the United States that the intermediate period of ten years was fixed. While there may be differences of opinion as to whether this period is too long or too short all must agree that if our trade relations with the United States during the Commonwealth should prove more injurious to our country than they would under complete independence, the Philippines would then do well to hasten the date of separation from America. This fact will not be revealed to us until after the first years of the Commonwealth and we have known the result of the economic conference between representatives of the United States and the Philippines which, I trust, will be called by the President of the United States at an early date.

Meanwhile, I consider it a most disturbing influence which will retard our work of economic readjustment and reconstruction, for anyone to advocate now the shortening of the transition period. What the country direly needs to-day is a period of stability and business confidence so that we may proceed unhampered in the task of erecting our new Government and building up the national economy to increase the wealth of the nation, promote commerce, agriculture, and industry; improve the condition of our wage-earners, and create economic opportunities for all our citizens. We need to give capital reasonable certainty as to those conditions which affect investment; we need to assure the industries that are dependent upon the free American market that no radical changes will take place which will bring about a sudden loss of the market on which they depend; we need above all to provide economic security for the masses of our people which can only be accomplished through the maintenance of stable business conditions.

I yield to no one in my fervent desire to see the Philip-pines independent as soon as possible, but I cannot close my eyes to the fact that a difference of a few years may mean a great deal to the well-being of our people and the permanence of our national liberty. Besides, we should not be deluded into believing that it is possible for anyone at this time to obtain from Congress the shortening of the transition period. All the pleas that may now be submitted in support of this action had already been considered and passed upon by that body. No new reason can be advanced that had not been already submitted. Therefore, making an issue of the shortening of the transition period is unfair to our people and most injurious to their interests.

I am anxious to see our independence established at the earliest possible date. I look upon it as the most precious reward for the many years of ceaseless efforts that I have spent in its quest. I pledge myself anew resolutely to take all necessary steps leading to the advent of independence, and to do everything in my power to make the Philippine Republic strong and enduring, and the blessings of liberty not only the cherished possession of this generation but the priceless heritage of the Filipino people for all the time.

“Commonwealth Act No. 1 An Act to Provide for the National Defense of the Philippines, Penalizing Certain Violations Thereof, Appropriating Funds Therefor, And for Other Purposes” Accessed December 4, 2020.

Source: <https://www.officialgazette.gov.ph/1935/12/21/commonwealth-act-no-1/>

One the first laws passed by the National Assembly and enacted by the Philippine Commonwealth was the National Defense Act of 1935. The Commonwealth Act No. 1 aimed for the creation of an independent military for the Philippines. Prior to the creation of this act, the Office of the Military Advisor to the Commonwealth Government under the U.S. General Douglas MacArthur heeded the call of President Quezon to form a system of national defense towards the independence of the Philippines.

The section of the law provided shows the articles on the personnel such as enlistment, the creation of the military academy, and provision for a reserve force with reserved and noncommissioned officers. The law provided for the drafting of Filipino men, between the ages of 21 and 50. The Philippine Military Academy would provide the training of selected candidates for permanent commission in the Regular Force while the Reserve Units would come from colleges and universities in the Philippines.

EXCERPT:

ARTICLE III

Enlistment and Reenlistment

SECTION 27. Any male citizen of the Philippines between eighteen and thirty years of age, able-bodied, free from disease, of good moral character and habits, of average intelligence, and possessed of such educational attainments as may be prescribed, may be enlisted in the Regular Force under the following restrictions:

- (a) Enlistments shall be for a term of three years, and may be made by the recruiting officers at stations of the Regular Force.
- (b) Unmarried minors between eighteen and twenty-one years of age may be enlisted only on the written and duly attested consent of the father, the mother when she is the only surviving parent, or the publicly known guardian.
- (c) Enlistments for service in any province, except for the Regular Division, the Artillery Corps, and Air Corps, shall be from among residents thereof. In so far as practicable, enlistments in these forces shall be apportioned among the various provinces of the Philippines.

SECTION 28. Regulations applying to the reenlistment and to the retirement privileges of noncommissioned officers of the Regular Force shall be prescribed by the President.

SECTION 29. An enlisted man who shall have served honorably at least three years and does not reenlist shall be exempt from further military service except in a national emergency. He shall be required, however, to register his address at the military headquarters nearest to his place of residence.

ARTICLE IV

Military Academy

SECTION 30. There shall be established a military training school to be named the Philippine Military Academy, for the training of selected candidates for permanent commission in the Regular Force. The student body in the Military Academy shall be known as the Cadet Corps of the Army of the Philippines.

SECTION 31. The President is authorized to appoint to the Military Academy annually, subject to such physical and mental examinations as he may prescribe, the number of cadets necessary to maintain the Cadet Corps at a strength of not to exceed three hundred and fifty. Cadets shall be selected from among qualified candidates as hereinafter provided. Candidates for admission shall be single, in good physical condition, not less than seventeen nor more than twenty-two years of age, and shall be nominated by the Members of the National Assembly, each of whom may nominate any number of candidates. The President shall appoint from among those who pass the physical and mental examinations with the highest ratings the number or numbers necessary to fill the existing vacancies: Provided, That a quota of three members of the Cadet Corps shall be allotted to each Assembly district: Provided, further, That in case no candidates from a given Assembly district attain the required minimum ratings, a second examination shall be given during the same year to nominees from that district. If on the second examination no candidate shall attain the required minimum rating, the vacancies in the district quota shall be filled by the President from successful candidates at large.

The pay and allowances of students at the Military Academy shall be fixed by the President.

Any student who shall, after entrance to the Academy and before completion of the prescribed course of training, be found to be physically unfit for military duty by reason of injury or disease incident to the service, shall be retired with the rank of cadet and shall be entitled to the retired pay and allowances of a third lieutenant of the Regular Force.

Upon satisfactory completion of the course of instruction at the Military Academy candidates shall be commissioned third lieutenants in the Regular or Reserve Forces with relative rank in the order of final general standing as determined by the Faculty Board and Commandant of the Academy, and approved by the Chief of Staff.

ARTICLE V

The Reserve Force

SECTION 32. The Reserve Force shall consist of such number of Infantry Divisions located as the President may direct; of such additional separate regiments, battalions, companies, and similar separate units as the President may authorize; of all reserve classes not assigned to the above units, and of the Reserve elements of the Offshore Patrol.

The organization of reserve land and air units shall, in so far as practicable, be that of corresponding tactical units of the Regular Force.

SECTION 33. The Chief of Staff may detail or assign to duty with Reserve units such enlisted men of the Regular Force as he deems necessary.

ARTICLE VI

Reserve Officers and Noncommissioned Officer

SECTION 34. Any person who shall have completed his trainee instruction and who is selected for training as a commissioned officer shall pursue a theoretical course of training of not less than six months to be prescribed by the Chief of Staff, upon completion of which he shall be assigned to duty with a Regular unit as probationary third lieutenant for another period of six months. At the end of this service those who have displayed qualities of leadership and who have demonstrated their fitness to command may be appointed and commissioned third lieutenants of the Reserve Force and assigned to an organization thereof. Those who fail to complete the course of training shall be transferred to the Reserve Force as enlisted men and shall be assigned to an organization thereof.

SECTION 35. At such colleges and universities as the President may designate there shall be established and maintained Reserve Officers' Training Units of such arms and services as he shall specify, where every physically fit student shall be required to pursue a course of military instruction designed to qualify him for a commission as a third lieutenant of Reserve. In so far as may be practicable, the student shall be permitted to choose the arm or service in which he wishes to train. This course of military instruction, if pursued to completion, shall exempt students from trainee instruction. It shall not exempt them from registration.

SECTION 36. The Chief of Staff shall, by mutual agreement with the head of the institution, designate the senior military instructor and such commissioned and enlisted personnel as may be necessary for each institution. He is authorized to issue to such institutions the arms, equipment and other property which he deems essential to the conduct of this instruction.

SECTION 37. Each year the senior military instructor shall submit to the Chief of Staff the names of those members of the graduating class whom he recommends for further training. These graduates may be ordered to organizations of the Regular Force for a six months' probationary period. At the end of this service those who have displayed their fitness for Commission may be appointed and commissioned third lieutenants of the Reserves and assigned to an organization thereof.

SECTION 38. Graduates who are not recommended for training as third lieutenants and those who fail to qualify for appointment as such shall be assigned to the nearest age group in the Reserve and assigned to an organization thereof as private or noncommissioned officers as recommended. Students of military age who do not complete their courses of study at an institution of learning provided with a Reserve Officers' Training Unit shall be liable for trainee instruction immediately upon severing their connection with the institution. If more than 20 years of age, they shall be assigned to the trainee class next to be called.

SECTION 39. The President shall appoint and commission, upon the recommendation of the Chief of Staff, such reserve officers as shall in his opinion be needed.

SECTION 40. In so far as may be practicable, original appointments by the President in grades above third lieutenant shall be made from among those formerly holding Reserve commissions in the United States Army and from former officers of the Philippine Scouts and Constabulary.

SECTION 41. Noncommissioned officers of the Regular Force between the ages of twenty-one and thirty years who are recommended for appointment as third lieutenants shall pursue the course of instruction of six months prescribed for those who have completed their trainee instruction, and who are recommended for training to qualify as reserve officers. Upon satisfactory completion of this course they may be appointed and commissioned third lieutenants of the Reserves and assigned to an organization of the Reserve Force. Except upon mobilization, no service as a reserve officer may be performed by an enlisted man of the Regular Force.

SECTION 42. Medical reserve officers shall be procured from graduates of medical colleges and universities under such regulations as may be prescribed by the President.

SECTION 43. Reserve officers shall be physically examined upon each assignment to active duty. Any reserve officer found physically unfit for active field service shall be discharged.

SECTION 44. Young men who complete their trainee instruction and are selected for additional training to qualify them as noncommissioned officers of the Reserve Force shall pursue a prescribed course of three months. Upon satisfactory completion thereof they shall be warranted in the noncommissioned officer grade for which they shall have qualified, and then transferred to the Reserve Force and assigned to an organization thereof.

SECTION 45. The Chief of Staff shall be empowered to organize and establish such special and advanced school units as he may deem proper for the special training of officers of the technical and supply sections and services, and for the advanced training of selected officers for field, staff, and command duties.

SECTION 46. All candidates for appointment as reserve officers, except medical officers, shall be required to qualify for appointment as third lieutenants of the line before being permitted to pursue any special course pertaining to the technical and supply services.

ARTICLE VII

Active Duty Training of Reservists

SECTION 47. Periods of active duty training in the Reserve Force shall be as prescribed by the Chief of Staff. In so far as may be practicable, the active duty periods for the three echelons shall be as follows: First Reserves, annually, not less than ten days; Second Reserves, annually, not less than five days; and Third Reserves, every third year, not less than seven days.

During such periods of active duty training the reservist shall be amenable to the laws and regulations prescribed for the Regular Force. Except with his own consent, no enlisted reservist may be required in time of peace to serve more than thirty days on active duty in any calendar year.

SECTION 48. Any reservist who fails to report for active duty training as directed by the Chief of Staff shall be punished as a court-martial may direct.

SECTION 49. Any employee of the Government called for trainee instruction, or for regular annual active duty training, shall not be compelled to lose his position or to suffer a loss of pay due to his absence in the fulfillment of his military obligations.

SECTION 50. Mobilization centers shall be constituted as follows:

(a) Mobilization centers shall be established for the purpose of providing storage for the arms, equipment, clothing, and records of units, other than those of the Regular Force, to be mobilized in a national emergency, of making provision in advance of mobilization for the necessary shelter for men and animals of such units during mobilization, and of reducing to a minimum the period necessary for mobilization.

(b) One mobilization center shall be established for each battalion or similar unit or, when for the best interests of the Philippines, for regiments or larger units.

(c) Provincial Commanders, acting under the Chief of Staff, shall be responsible that all arms, equipment, and other material stored in such buildings within their respective provinces are properly cared for and secured, and that all records turned over to the chief caretaker by military units are preserved intact.

The Constabulary shall, whenever practicable, be charged under the Provincial Commanders with the care of the arms, equipment and other materials, and of the records at mobilization centers.

United States. High Commissioner to the Philippine Islands. 1936. *Annual Report of the United States High Commissioner to the Philippine Islands Commissioner to the Philippine Islands Covering the Calendar Year 1935-1936*. Washington: U.S. G.P.O. Accessed December 4, 2010.

Source: <https://catalog.hathitrust.org/Record/100145145/Home>

By the Commonwealth period, the highest position held by an American official in the Philippines is the High Commissioner to the Philippine Islands. This is an excerpt from the annual report sent by Frank Murphy, the first High Commissioner, to the United States government.

The excerpt below shows a reporting of the Sakdal demonstration in Manila on October 3, 1936. The Manila demonstration was part of the series of activities of the Sakdal Party. Founded by Benigno Ramos in 1930, the Sakdal Party was a populist movement that advocated for Philippine nationalism and independence and agrarian socialism. Most of their activity revolved in Central Luzon such as the provinces of Laguna, Rizal, Bulacan, Nueva Ecija, and Pampanga.

Excerpt:

VI. PUBLIC ORDER

26. Two minor disturbances.—Public order was good during the period under report, except for two minor disturbances.

The first of these was an outbreak of brigandage in the mountains of Laguna, which began a short time before the end of the former regime. The Commonwealth President went to Laguna soon after his inauguration and gave this matter his personal attention to such effect that the outbreak was suppressed in a very short time.

A terroristic demonstration in the city of Manila on the evening of October 3, 1936, was the subject of an inquiry from the Bureau of Insular Affairs. This inquiry and the reply by the Acting High Commissioner were as follows:

[Extra priority radio no. 740]

WASHINGTON, October 21, 1936.

UNITED STATES HIGH COMMISSIONER,

Manila:

Press dispatches of 19th instant report terrorist plots to create disturbances through assassinations, bombings, etc. Please radio brief summary of the facts as developed to date.

COX.

[Extra priority radio]

OCTOBER 22, 1936.

SECRETARY OF WAR,

Washington (Cox):

Reference your no. 740 October 21, an outbreak occurred October 3 shortly after 8 o'clock p. m. in the city of Manila. Four explosions were heard, eight fires started, and there were four attempts at arson, all within a period of 3 hours. Parsons Hardware near the Ayala Bridge and nearby buildings were damaged to the extent of 1,000,000 pesos. One water main in Santa Mesa was broken by explosives, shutting off the water supply to a large section of Manila for several hours.

Theodoro Navarro and Lorenzo Galang, said to be leaders of Sakdals, were arrested October 5. They denied having participated in the acts of October 3, but news stories later indicated they were involved in confessions reported in the press October 20. Many of the news stories are vague and give the impression of reportorial guesswork.

Since October 3 police have found bombs in several Manila buildings and seven bombs were reported found upon the arrest of five members of Sakdal party at Malabon October 18. Newspaper of October 20 carried stories that "Sakdal terror plot spreading." These stories followed the arrest of the five Sakdal leaders mentioned above. Confessions as reported by the press were to the effect that Sakdals planned to set fire Manila on the night of October 3 and then sweep the five nearby Provinces and take control of municipal and provincial governments. According to press reports leaders stated in confessions that they lost their nerve when they entered Manila and heard the explosions on night of October 3.

Philippine Army officials report that there is no truth in the statement that a plot was unearthed to assassinate Government officials including the Archbishop and the High Commissioner, but rather that the persons questioned denied there was any such plot. They report that no communications have been received by local Sakdalistas from Ramos for about 1 year and there is no organized opposition to any activities of the Government; that such acts of terrorism that have occurred have been sporadic and not a part of a general plan; that the present unrest is confined to the city of Manila and the provinces of Rizal, Bulacan, Nueva Ecija, and Pampanga, and that there is peace and order in all other parts of the Philippines including Laguna, Cavite, and Batangas Provinces. The reports received today indicate a plan for an uprising in the vicinity of Manila on November 1. The general public seems very little disturbed. United States Army officials, Philippine Army officials, and police officials are alert but not apprehensive. They believe that disorders are local in character, poorly led, poorly financed, and loosely organized.

They report that labor groups in Manila are restive because of the failure of wages to be advanced in the face of advances in prices of commodities and more prosperous times among manufacturing, shipping, and commercial interests. The recent typhoons did considerable damage to the rice crop which has caused suffering in Central Luzon and the Cagayan Valley. This suffering, according to reports, was quite acute but is being rapidly alleviated. Tenant farmers are complaining because landlords have insisted upon advance payments of cash rent when customarily they have been content to receive rents on installments. Dissatisfaction with authorities is attributed by some as a protest against announcement by President Quezon that on account of present unrest he did not intend to release political prisoners on November 15 as previously announced. Others believe that the Government is magnifying reports of violence as justification for building up the Philippine Army. Philippine Army officials however deplore the publicity given to reports of disorders as they say that such reports are frequently erroneous and nearly always exaggerated. Bulletin this morning has eight-column headline, "Fear New Sakdal Outbreak", this being based on a rumor that "a big haul of rifles and ammunition was smuggled into one of the coast towns of the Philippines." The Bulletin story goes on to say "the tense situation is further aggravated by the flight of the Sakdal leaders to the mountains, the reported burial of all "red" documents and the seething unrest among the radical followers of the political prisoners who lost their chances of early freedom when President Quezon decided not to give them amnesty." The Philippine Army officials state that there is no truth in the statement that rifles and ammunition were smuggled into one of the coast towns nor has there been a flight of Sakdal leaders to the mountains. There are very few political prisoners as Governor Murphy pardoned the majority of all those convicted for participating in the disorders of May 1935 and since that time President Quezon has pardoned a number. I believe there is no cause for apprehension here. The Government is in strong hands and I believe the Philippine authorities are doing everything in their power to relieve the suffering and to improve the lot of the poor and unemployed. President Quezon is in very close touch with the situation and with all classes of people. He has visited devastated areas and has come in contact first hand with the sufferers. The

Assembly has just appropriated \$ 1,500,000 to relieve the situation. United States Army and Navy authorities see no reason to be alarmed.

My weekly reports sent by air mail to High Commissioner Murphy give all details as I get them from press and from other sources. This radio is based upon reports received from military authorities of the United States Army, naval authorities, and Philippine Army authorities, inquiries made from numerous individuals and reports in the press and personal observation of myself and staff

JONES

**Letter of President Quezon on Three-point Policy for Mindanao and Sulu, October 08,
1937**

This document was crafted by Jorge Vargas, and serves as a reply of President Quezon to a letter sent by Sultan Ombra Amilbangsa, an assemblyman representing Sulu. Amilbangsa sent a letter expressing his concerns over the policies defining the Commonwealth government's administration over Mindanao and Sulu. Jorge Vargas (1890-1980) was a lawyer and diplomat, who served in Quezon's cabinet as the executive secretary from 1936 to 1941. Later on, he became the secretary of national defense in 1941.

Ambilbagsa agreed with the policy to give a broader power to the Commissioner of Mindanao and Sulu as overseer of administrative affairs, However, he laments the nonrecognition of the various existent titles across different areas in Mindanao, asks for consultation on the appointment of army officers as governors in the Moro provinces, and concludes with identifying himself as belonging to group of the supporters of his administration not as passive yielders but as engaging allies offering constructive criticisms and suggestion to policy and programs.

Letter of President Quezon on Three-point Policy for Mindanao and Sulu, October 8, 1937

Letter*

of

His Excellency Manuel L. Quezon

President of the Philippines

On Three-Point Policy for Mindanao and Sulu

[Released on October 8, 1937]

Sir:

I have the honor to inform you that your letter of the 2nd instant, addressed to His Excellency, the President, in which you comment on his "three-point policy" on the affairs of Mindanao and Sulu, has been received. In this connection permit me to call your attention to the fact that in his memorandum to the Secretary of the Interior dated September 20, 1937, His Excellency does not seek to interfere with the use of titles by Moro sultans or datos so long as it is clearly understood that a title carries with it no official rights or privileges. What the President desires to emphasize is that there are no privileged classes under this Government and no authority vested on any

individual not occupying an official position. In other words, the President is determined to consider and to act towards the Mohammedan Filipinos as he considers and acts towards the Christians, precisely because he agrees with you that the so-called Moro problem is a myth.

His Excellency appreciates your kind interest in his administration, particularly in matters affecting your district, and he wishes me to inform you that your recommendation for the retention of Major Leon Angeles as Provincial Governor of Sulu for the time being, will be given due consideration.

Very respectfully,

Jorge B. Vargas

Secretary to the President

Hon. Ombra Amilbangsa

National Assembly

Manila

* This is a reply to a letter of Assemblyman Ombra Amilbangsa, which is as follows:

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

MANILA

October 2, 1937

His Excellency

The PRESIDENT OF THE PHILIPPINES

Malacañan Palace

Manila

Dear Mr. President:

1. In recent issues of the local dailies, I read with deep interest the released copy of Your Excellency's Memorandum, addressed to the Honorable, the Secretary of the Interior, in which Your Excellency's "Three-Point Policies," defining how affairs in Moroland are to be

administered, was embodied. As Your Excellency's loyal supporter, I cannot let the news pass without commenting on the policies, especially in their relations to my district.

2. The policy of giving a free hand to the Commissioner of Mindanao and Sulu on all plans he may deem fit to execute is indeed plausible and commendable, and it could not have been otherwise. As a matter of fact, I joined Assemblymen Fortich and Cabili in endorsing that policy to Your Excellency when the measure was yet pending the action of the National Assembly.

3. As to the non-recognition of the various titles, a practice still adhered to by the various Mohammedan elements in Mindanao and Sulu, I think, Mr. President, the policy as released covering this subject was most unnecessary, as the non-recognition has already taken effect since the abrogation of the Bates Treaty and the implantation of the Civil Government in the regions referred to. In the agreement concluded between the Sultan of Sulu and Frank Carpenter, then Secretary of the Department of Mindanao and Sulu, the former is recognized as a temporal head of that region and as such his office is confined to religious activities. In the light of these facts the Government, I think, Mr. President, has no right to interfere with them so long as no law or order is infringed. The religious titles ever since in vogue in the Mohammedan regions are akin to religious titles enjoyed and practiced by the different Christian sects.

4. The policy of suppressing the practice of appointing army officers as governors in Moro provinces is one thing about which I beg to be allowed to discuss at length and with liberty. The administration dating back to the early American administrators, had initiated various policies principally intended to maintain peace and order, but lamentably never promulgated policies to effect universal improvements in those regions. As a result of this uncomprehensive plan, the accomplishments were nothing more than the blowing out of the Moro cottas and enactment of other bloody dramas. Judging from the records of the past, it seems that questions of efficiency of administration in Moroland depend in a large measure, upon the personal ability, integrity and far-sightedness of the local administrator rather than by imposing rigid obedience to mutable policies.

5. Regarding the present incumbent, Major Leon Angeles, his administration since his appointment is one worthy of praise and commendation. His experience and adeptness in understanding conditions obtaining in the province, make him the most logical man to remain in the position for sometime until Your Excellency think otherwise. He is the most capable Filipino governor ever appointed to that position. I believe that in justice to the incumbent, Your Excellency should allow him to remain for sometime in order that he could accomplish the projects he has just started.

6. Talks of Moro problems, both of the past and the present, have been the topics deafening the ears of the public. The Moros, myself included, are ignorant of the so-called Moro problems, and we emphatically deny its existence.

7. In passing, I beg leave to state that in Mindanao Your Excellency has two groups of supporters: the first are those who readily yield assent to what Your Excellency say, and the second, those who study Your Excellency's policy and offer constructive criticisms and suggestions to the end that the country may be benefited. I am happy that I belong to the second group so that if I express myself openly and frankly, it is because it is my honest and sincere belief that in doing so, I am helping and coöperating with Your Excellency to perfect a policy conducive to the general welfare of my people.

Respectfully yours,

(Sgd.) SULTAN OMBRA AMILBANGSA

Assemblyman for Sulu

Alzona, Encarnacion. 1937. “*The Significance of the Women Suffrage Referendum*” in *Encarnacion Alzona: An Anthology*. edited by Maria Luisa Camagay. Quezon City: Office of Research Coordination, University of the Philippines, 1996.

Encarnacion Alzona (1895-2001) was one of the revered women historians and educators in the twentieth century Philippines. She was awarded as one of the National Scientists of the Philippines in the field of History in 1985.

In this article, she wrote the importance of having a suffrage referendum that grants women the right to vote. Alzona, who was the first woman to receive a doctorate degree in history, studied the history of education, specifically the women’s education in history. Her study, *The Filipino Woman: Her Social, Economic and Political Status (1565-1933)*, attested the inherent equality of Filipino women to men despite being deprived of education and political rights. Along with prominent women, she championed support for women's suffrage through her writing such as this published in periodical, *The Woman’s World*. Filipino women obtained the right to vote in 1937.

EXCERPT:

On April 30 Filipino women throughout the Archipelago will vote on the question of woman suffrage. The referendum will determine whether or not the Filipino woman shall exercise the right of suffrage. Considering the large number of registrants, the support of influential men led by the President of the Philippine Commonwealth, and the earnestness of women leaders, the coming referendum promises to turn in favor of the suffragists.

We ardently hope that more than half a million women registrants will vote favorably on the question on April 30. Let no task on that day, women of the Philippines, deter you from going to the nearest precinct to cast your affirmative vote. To discharge this duty will require only a few minutes of your time, yet you will be taking away in a momentous event, unique in the history of our country. By referring to the Filipino women the question of suffrage, which affects not only themselves but the entire nation, is in itself an unequivocal admission on the part of the framers of our constitution of their confidence in the ability of Filipino woman to decide a national question. True to the Filipino tradition, our women would not impose a right and responsibility upon the women unless women themselves desire it. They have therefore given us the privilege of expressing our wishes on the subject.

Women of the Philippines, if you participate in the coming referendum your name shall be written indelibly on the pages of our history, and your descendants will be proud of you and call you emancipators of the women of your country.

Once you become an elector, you shall attain the same political status as the men. You can help directly elect to public office a worthy candidate; you can help defeat a dishonest and incapable aspirant. In a democratic country, the ballot is the most effective instrument in the hands of the average man. Without it the average man is a forgotten man; but with it, the average man becomes the most powerful man in the country. Government officials listen attentively to his pleas or complaints, knowing that he is a voter, whose vote on election day must be reckoned with. To the average man the ballot is an insurance against oppression and injustice; and let this be borne in mind by our women who will soon be enfranchised. As women voters, we can wield a salutary influence on politics if we use our power to combat corruption, injustice, and oppression. Let us be judicious in the use of our newly acquired right, aware of the responsibility that goes with it.

We are familiar with the electoral abuses which had been committed in the past. They were a blot on our political life. As voters we can help the recurrence of such evils by refusing to be a party in an unlawful scheme or vigorously denouncing any flagrant defiance of the election law. Let none of us be guilty of giving our right to vote for a paltry consideration. We must use it to bring the utmost good to society as whole.

The system of voting used in our country is the Australian ballot or the secret method of voting. It assures every voter absolute secrecy and liberty in voting. Through this system he can vote as he desires and he need not fear the political bosses of his locality.

After the grant of woman suffrage, our next campaign should be directed to making our women intelligent and vigilant citizens. This task will devolve upon the thousands of educated women scattered all over the Islands. It will be their duty to enlighten the mass of women of low educational attainment whose knowledge about their new right is vague or confused.